



Preferences for market justice in education: The role of meritocratic beliefs in a comparative perspective

Tesis de Magíster

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Abstract

Palabras clave: Market justice preferences; Education; Meritocratic beliefs; Cross-country; Macrostructural factors

1 Introduction

The commodification of education has been one of the most significant transformations in the organization of welfare states over the past few decades. Although education has traditionally been a social service guaranteed by the state, many countries have undergone a process of commodification that has led to a relative decline in public funding and an expansion of private education provision (Busemeyer & Iversen, 2020; Esping-Andersen, 1985; Lindh, 2015; OECD, 2025). This shift toward market logic has not only transformed the institutional functioning of education systems but also people's beliefs and preferences regarding how educational opportunities should be distributed, demonstrating the impact of economic organization on micro-level dynamics (Busemeyer, 2012; Busemeyer et al., 2018; Koos & Sachweh, 2019). In some cases, these beliefs have led to the legitimization of educational inequality (Castillo, Iturra, et al., 2025; Piketty & Sandel, 2025)

Meritocracy holds that social rewards should be distributed on the basis of individual effort and talent, making it one of the main normative principles associated with both education and distributional preferences (Sandel, 2020). Various studies have shown that meritocratic beliefs are linked to higher acceptance of inequality, as they attribute success and failure primarily to individual responsibility, functioning as a cultural mechanism that justifies social hierarchies and diminishes perceptions of structural factors that shape individual trajectories (Darnon et al., 2018; Heuer et al., 2020; Mau, 2015; Mijs, 2016; Mijs, 2021). However, the understanding of meritocratic beliefs has evolved in recent years, no longer being viewed as a one-dimensional phenomenon, but rather as capable of co-existing with other beliefs that acknowledge structural conditions and privilege, thereby overcoming a methodological and theoretical limitation (Castillo et al., 2023; Zhu, 2025). Within the multidimensional framework of meritocracy, some studies have proposed a distinction between meritocratic perceptions and structural perceptions (Zhu, 2025); oth-

ers have focused on descriptive and ascriptive dimensions of effort, talent, and privilege (Castillo et al., 2023; Duru-Bellat & Tenret, 2012; Sin et al., 2026).

Several studies have examined the effect of education on the justification of inequalities (Liu & Wang, 2026; Nye et al., 2026), or the relationship between meritocracy and perceptions of inequality (Bartram, 2023; Castillo, Iturra, et al., 2025; Mijs, 2021), but to our knowledge, no research has examined market preferences in education and their relationship to meritocratic beliefs from a multidimensional and comparative perspective. To fill this gap, this study aims to analyze the role of meritocratic beliefs in preferences for market justice in education and their interaction with institutional contexts. The concept of market justice refers to the belief that access to and the quality of social services should be determined by individual or family ability to pay, and is thus associated with the legitimization of inequalities from a market-oriented perspective. (Lane, 1986; Lindh, 2015).

This study aims to answer three questions: (1) To what extent do meritocratic beliefs influence preferences for market justice in education? (2) How do institutional designs and preferences for market justice in education interact? (3) Are there significant differences across countries? We argue that preferences for market justice in education are closely related to two factors: meritocratic beliefs and a country’s institutional designs. On the one hand, meritocratic beliefs have been shown to be a determinant of distributional preferences and perceptions of inequality, where those who perceive more meritocracy are likely to be more inclined to prefer market justice in education [; Castillo et al. (2026); Castillo, Laffert, et al. (2025); Castillo et al. (2024); Darnon et al. (2018); Heuer et al. (2020); Mijs (2021)]. On the other hand, countries’ institutional designs appear to be an important factor in shaping people’s beliefs (Busemeyer, 2013; Liu & Wang, 2026), and we hypothesize that countries with higher levels of economic inequality, as well as those with greater public investment in education, will exhibit an aversion to market justice in education.

To address these issues, we use data from the 2019 International Social Survey Program (ISSP), the World Inequality Database (WID), and UNESCO. First, we apply latent class analysis to identify profiles of meritocratic beliefs, and then conduct multinomial logistic regression to examine the relationship between these profiles and preferences for market

justice in education, while incorporating sociodemographic and institutional factors. In doing so, this research aims to contribute to the literature on the relationship between perceptions of inequality and meritocracy, placing special emphasis on micro-level foundations and their interaction with institutional contexts to understand how beliefs about educational inequality are formed.

2 Theoretical and empirical background

2.1. Market justice preferences

Welfare states have undergone several institutional transformations in recent years, with private expansion strongly penetrating the field of social services alongside public provision ([Busemeyer & Iversen, 2020](#)). Such processes have led to changes in the architecture of the institutions responsible for social welfare. On the one hand, private companies operate as service administrators of benefits based on the user's ability to pay, whereas on the other hand, public providers have reorganized to compete as quasi-markets ([Lindh, 2017](#)). Besides changes at the formal level, the commodification of social services shapes cultural norms and beliefs, where markets operate as moral projects ([Fourcade & Healy, 2007](#); [Koos & Sachweh, 2019](#)).

The field of distributive justice has gradually incorporated market preferences into attitudinal research on redistribution. Since Kluegel's seminal work ([1981](#)) on the normative foundations of beliefs about social stratification, the concept of market justice preferences has been developed, understood as the normative principle that legitimizes access to goods and services according to an individual's or family's ability to pay ([Lane, 1986](#)). This principle is closely linked to the justification of inequalities: by conceiving the market as a space of equal opportunities, economic success is interpreted as an individual achievement ([J. R. Kluegel et al., 1999](#)), disregarding the structural conditions that produce such disparities. In this way, market justice operates simultaneously as an economic and moral principle that legitimizes socioeconomic inequalities.

Most research in this field relies on survey data, in which questions about market justice directly probe support for the provision of social services—education, pensions, and health care—based on individual ability to pay (e.g., “Is it fair that high-income

individuals receive better education than low-income individuals?”) (Busemeyer, 2013; Lindh, 2015). Within this framework, ISSP has been the primary source for advancing this agenda. Also, recent research has employed both indices constructed from relevant items (Castillo, Laffert, et al., 2025) and a separate analysis of each item.

Education is one of the key dimensions in the study of market justice, given the commodification processes educational systems have undergone in recent decades. The growing prominence of the private sector in education, coupled with the implementation of market-driven logic, has transformed the structure of educational systems, where students and their families are viewed as consumers of a service (Brancaleone & O’Brien, 2011; Lindh, 2015). These changes have ethical consequences, as education loses its intrinsic value and becomes a means of generating monetary value, and its quality is often determined by the type of funding, thereby reinforcing socioeconomic inequalities (Abowitz & Stitzlein, 2018; Ball, 2004; Piketty & Sandel, 2025; Satz, 2010). In this sense, market justice in education conflicts with educational justice by denying equity in quality and universal access to education.

Recent literature on market preferences has identified significant associations at both the individual and contextual levels. At the individual level, socioeconomic status emerges as a consistent predictor; those in more advantaged positions tend to exhibit greater preferences for market justice (Koos & Sachweh, 2019; Lindh, 2015), a pattern reflecting a moral economy oriented toward justifying status for those who benefit from the market order. In this regard, political ideology shows a clear association, with right-leaning individuals tending to favor market-oriented distributional principles (Castillo et al., 2024; Lee & Stacey, 2024). At the contextual level, the relative weight of private and public service provision emerges as a structuring factor in preferences; in countries where private investment predominates, individuals tend to internalize the market order as a criterion of justice and, consequently, to reduce their redistributive preferences; whereas the opposite trend is observed where public provision prevails (Busemeyer, 2013; Immergut & Schneider, 2020; Lindh, 2015).

2.2. Education and legitimization of inequalities

Education is one of the core pillars of societal structure, but the role it plays has been the subject of an unresolved debate. From a theoretical perspective, education plays an ambivalent role: on the one hand, it has been argued that it promotes access to opportunities, skill development, and the reduction of social inequalities. This perspective is supported by various mechanisms, such as human capital development and/or the development of critical awareness of structural problems (Becker, 1993; Freire, 2015; Schultz, 1961). On the other hand, education has been understood as a source of social inequalities, as it reproduces individuals' living conditions, preventing opportunities for intergenerational social mobility and, consequently, perpetuating the stratified order. These approaches have developed primarily through theories that draw on symbolic violence and social reproduction as mechanisms for legitimizing inequalities (Bourdieu, 2019; Bowles & Gintis, 2011). Thus, education can be understood through its enlightening role in social life, but also as a cog in the reproduction of inequalities in society.

Recent literature provides empirical support for these two theoretical approaches to education. For example, research by Bubak (2019) found that higher levels of education are negatively associated with support for meritocracy, acknowledging that structural conditions determine individual outcomes. Along the same lines, using the 2009 ISSP survey, Zhu (2025) found that in Finland, the enlightening effect of education was present, unlike in the United States and China. In contrast, the research by Diwan & Vartanova (2020) concluded that states deliberately use education to shape students' political attitudes in order to reproduce national identity. Likewise, Van Noord et al. (2019) used data from 31 countries to show that education is widely understood as the basis for social stratification. However, the results from Liu & Wang (2026) suggest that education does not fulfill a generalized function; rather, both the enlightening and the reproductionist roles exist but depend on the macro context, where the enlightening role is present in countries with low levels of inequality, while the legitimizing role is observed in countries with high levels of inequality.

Besides to the functional role of education, a vast body of literature has situated education within the framework of redistributive preferences. In a cross-country study, Busemeyer et al. (2018) found that education is the policy field with the highest level

of support for spending; however, when distinguishing between types of spending, higher levels of investment in private education are negatively associated with preferences for redistribution (Busemeyer, 2013). In country-specific studies such as those in Australia and Chile, most respondents stated that they consider it unfair for the quality of education to depend on parents' ability to pay (Castillo, Iturra, et al., 2025; Lee & Stacey, 2024). Furthermore, based on correlational and experimental evidence, Soler-Martínez et al. (2025) found that perceived educational inequality is associated with greater intolerance of inequality.

Surveys have been the primary tool for studying educational inequalities, measuring the concept through individuals' perceptions. In this frame, ISSP, as one of the most globally recognized surveys for measuring inequality, poses the question: *"Is it fair that high-income individuals have better education than lower-income individuals?"*. Some studies have incorporated this operationalization into national surveys (Castillo, Iturra, et al., 2025). Other studies have developed questions aimed at measuring the perceived gap in educational inequality (*i.e.*, *"In your judgment, how large or small are the differences in education between the rich and poor in Spain?"*) (Soler-Martínez et al., 2025). Busemeyer et al. (2018) conducted a survey in which the focus of the question was on the distribution of education spending, rather than on the judgment of inequality: *Let's talk about the distribution of public spending in the education sector. Please tell me whether you would like to see more or less government spending in each of the following areas. Keep in mind that 'more' or 'much more' might require a tax increase.* All operationalizations share the general objective of measuring educational inequalities, but each employs a different strategy and focuses on a distinct dimension of the concept.

3 Methods

4 Results

5 Discussion

6 Conclusions

7 References

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